

A COMPANION TO THE PUBLISHER PROMOTION FRAMEWORK

The Greatest Story Ever Told

A 20-part YouTube series — series at a glance & production plan

Prepared by **Bear Grylls Ventures** · 13 May 2026

For **Andy Lyon**, Hodder Faith — ahead of 14 May call

Where this fits

This document is a companion to the *Publisher Promotion Framework* shared earlier this year. That framework set out a portfolio of ten ideas Hodder could own; this is the executable plan for **Idea #1 — a dedicated YouTube channel for the book**, evolved into a fully-scoped series we are now ready to commission.

It is deliberately tighter than the framework version: one reader instead of five, one batch shoot instead of an open-ended commissioning brief, one anniversary launch instead of a slow ramp. Everything else in the framework (audiobook clips, IG, Substack, calendar anchors, Give One Away) still stands behind it.

The pitch

A 20-part YouTube series built from The Greatest Story Ever Told audiobook — one chapter per episode, professionally filmed, designed to drive sustained discovery of the book through the most-watched video platform in the world.

The shape of the thing

Title	The Greatest Story Ever Told
Format	YouTube long-form, immersive audiobook series
Episodes	20 (one per audiobook chapter)
Episode length	8:30 – 10:30 minutes (clears YouTube mid-roll ad threshold)
Run length	40 weeks — fortnightly drop
Launch	Thursday 19 June 2026 — book's first UK pub anniversary
Final episode	Early April 2027 — lands inside the Easter window
Channel	"The Greatest Story" on YouTube (created, dormant — held for launch)
Audience	The Chosen viewers, mainstream faith-curious, Bear's existing readership
Bear's role	Patron, not host — archive / pre-recorded footage only, no new filming
Commercial model	YouTube ad monetisation; every episode drives back to the book via end-card + description

What an episode actually looks like

Every episode is built on one chapter of the audiobook. The audio is the spine. The visual layer has two components, intercut:

THE READER

60–70%

A single professional performer, sitting and standing in a neutral studio set, silently performing the chapter while the audiobook plays beneath. The same reader appears across all 20 episodes — the recognisable human anchor of the series.

ATMOSPHERIC B-ROLL

30–40%

Cinematic cutaways matched to the chapter's setting and emotional beats — landscape, hands, candlelight, scripture text, ambient texture. No dialogue, no on-screen titles, no graphics overlays during the read.

The result is something between a long-form audiobook take and a contemplative short film. It clears YouTube's 8-minute threshold for mid-roll ads, suits the platform's algorithm preference for sequenced playlists, and gives the audiobook's existing performance the cinematic frame it deserves.

How it gets made

A **single batch shoot** captures all 20 chapters in 2–3 consecutive days at one London studio. Lighting is set once, the reader stays in character across all chapters, and the entire 40-week run becomes an editing exercise — no scheduling fragility, no re-shoots, no scene-matching between episodes.

PHASE	WINDOW	WHAT HAPPENS
Rights confirmation	This week	Hodder audiobook clip rights, editorial cut rights, YouTube monetisation rights confirmed in writing
Reader cast	21 May – 30 May	Longlist of 5–6 performers, screen tests, signed buyout-inclusive contract
Editor hire	22 May – 30 May	Freelance editor onboarded, briefed specifically for audiobook-over-picture cutting
Studio booked	By 6 June	London neutral studio, 2-day block confirmed, deposit paid
Pre-production	Early–mid June	Chapter-by-chapter mood boards, blocking, read-through with reader
Batch shoot	Tue–Wed 16–17 June	All 20 chapters filmed in one block
Episode 1 + trailer cut	17–18 June	Editor on set day 2; cuts episode 1 and 90-sec trailer in parallel to shoot wrap
Channel launch	Thu 19 June 2026	Episode 1 + trailer live; channel public

PHASE	WINDOW	WHAT HAPPENS
Steady-state delivery	Jun 2026 → Apr 2027	One new episode every two weeks, fed entirely from the single shoot

06 • WHY THIS SERVES THE BOOK

Five reasons this works for Hodder

- **The audiobook is the asset.** This format puts Hodder's existing recording in front of millions of new viewers on the platform they already use. The book is the destination, not a footnote.
- **One year of compounding discovery.** Forty weeks of consistent, high-quality output sustains the conversation around the book long past the launch news cycle — every episode is an evergreen entry point.
- **Calendar anchors are baked in.** The run is sequenced to put significant chapters at Advent, Christmas, Lent and Easter 2027, so the algorithm and the church calendar reinforce each other.
- **YouTube-native, not a podcast spillover.** Purpose-built for the platform where book discovery is increasingly happening — complementing, not competing with, the audiobook's existing distribution.
- **Bear's name carries it; Bear's bandwidth doesn't have to.** The patron framing means the series can run for a full year without depending on new Bear content, which has historically been the production bottleneck.

What we'd like to confirm with Hodder

- 1 Audiobook audio use** — permission to layer the existing audiobook recording underneath newly-filmed picture, across all 20 episodes.
- 2 Editorial cuts** — rights to cut and re-sequence the audiobook into 8-minute episode lengths suitable for YouTube.
- 3 YouTube monetisation** — confirmation that ad revenue on the episodes is in scope.
- 4 Short-form clips** — use of 30–60 second audiobook excerpts for promotional shorts across YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok in the run-up to and during launch.
- 5 Master delivery** — agreed path and timeline for clean audiobook audio masters to reach the editor by **Monday 9 June 2026**.

Anything Hodder would want baked into the brief — attribution lines, end-card requirements, monetisation splits, approval points along the run — we're happy to lock in now so the series ships clean from day one.

How we're de-risking it

- Reader is signed with a paid screen-test step before final commitment — on-camera presence is tested, not assumed.
- Editor has 60-day notice in the retainer, with a backup briefed lightly in case of mid-run departure.
- BGV operates the channel end-to-end; **Olly Westmacott** is the named owner for delivery, reporting to Jesse Grylls. Monthly KPI report shared with Hodder if helpful.
- No paid amplification at launch — the audience is grown organically on the back of clip-led discovery, so the channel proves itself before any spend is added.

Olly Westmacott · Market & Strategy Manager, BGV

Operating owner — *The Greatest Story Ever Told* YouTube series

BGV · The Greatest Story Ever Told · YouTube series overview · 13 May 2026